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one-day cricket also failed to strike a chord with fans and find context, and the year witnessed a solitary five-match series between England and Australia, despite the ICC Champions Trophy looming.

It was a thrilling year for Test cricket, with just three out of 50 matches being drawn as teams increasingly gunned for result-orientated pitches against the backdrop of the World Test Championship (WTC). The Proteas typified the dramatic year that was for the longest format.

From sending a second-string side to New Zealand owing to the absence of its top stars, who were engaged with the SA20 T20 franchise league, South Africa qualified for its first WTC final after a string of strong performances at home and a series sweep in Bangladesh, setting up a tantalising summit clash with defending champion Australia.

Breakneck speed

Test cricket also witnessed its fastest scoring year ever, with teams going at an average of 3.65 runs an over. England's subversive 'Bazball' style led the way, topping charts by scoring at 4.38 runs an over even if results didn't favour the Brendon McCullum-coached side.

But it wasn't just merrymaking for the batters as bowlers revelled in friendly conditions, with 2024 logging the lowest strike rate (48.6) in a year where at least 10 matches were played. Quite fittingly, the year had started with the shortest completed Test match ever, with India beating South Africa in just 107 overs in Cape Town.

There were as many as 21 away wins, a prized commodity in Test cricket, which included Bangladesh sweeping Pakistan, Sri Lanka winning in England, and New Zealand running riot in India.

These unexpected reverses should serve as a touchstone for the custodians of the game, who are contemplating a two-tier structure for Test cricket that could limit the possibility of these historic upsets that add to the game's folklore.

IN 2025...

India will look for a strong start to the new year in the limited-overs series against England at home, leading into the ICC Champions Trophy taking place for the first time since 2017.

The IPL, beginning in late March, will have an air of novelty as 10 freshly crafted teams will look to dethrone Kolkata Knight Riders.

India will hope to quickly recover from a disappointing end to 2024 in red-ball cricket as a daunting task awaits in the form of a five-Test tour of England in June, where the team will look to go one better than the 2-2 series result last time out. The post-R. Ashwin era of home Tests will get underway later in the year as West Indies and South Africa visit, and India looks to reclaim a place in the next WTC final.

The new year could also throw up some surprise announcements and elevations as a few Indian stalwarts head into the twilight of their careers.

The Indian Women's team will look to zero in on the best possible squad of players through the bilateral series and the Women's Premier League ahead of a home ODI World Cup in the second half of the year.